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Department of State

DATE:

SUBJECT

Guidance for Dealing with Space Objects Which Have Returned to Earth

REF

State 114584 (DTG 132148Z Feb 68)

E. O. 11652: XGDS-2

PFOR, PINR, TSPA, UN

This message supersedes previous instructions contained reftel which have been in effect for past five years and provides revised guidance to all US personnel serving abroad in an official capacity for dealing with space objects which have survived reentry and have impacted on the earth.

All posts should ensure that appropriate personnel, especially those who serve as duty officers, are aware of the guidance contained herein.

Background: The term "space object" is not clearly defined by international treaty. However, in general it may be construed to mean any object, including component parts, which has been placed in earth orbit or beyond. In addition to functioning satellites of various types, spent boosters, shrouds, fuel tanks, rocket nozzles, ballast, dummy payloads, etc., could also be considered space objects. For the purpose of this guidance, any hardware (whether intact major components or debris) from launches which were intended to achieve earth orbit but failed to do so should be

Attachment:

Extracts from Various Space Treaties and UN Resolutions Re Space

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considered as space objects. The procedures outlined herein would not apply to debris from surface-to-surface missile tests, even though the missiles may have passed through "outer space" during the ballistic phase of their flight.

[REDACTED] EC

In general, most space objects not specifically designed to withstand reentry burn up in the earth's atmosphere when they decay from orbit. However, from time to time a few space objects do survive reentry through the atmosphere and impact on the surface of the earth.

[REDACTED] EC

When a space object impacts on the earth and is recovered, a number of considerations and interests must be taken into account.

[REDACTED] EC

[REDACTED] EC

[REDACTED] In deciding how to proceed in each case, a careful assessment of these sometimes competing interests and obligations will be made by the interested agencies in Washington and a program of action will be designed to produce the maximum benefit to the US.

In all space object cases, it is the responsibility of the Department of State to insure that US interests are served --

[REDACTED] EC

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The designator "MOODUST" is used in cases involving the examination of non-US space objects or objects of unknown origin.

In the examination of an object, the following information should be obtained and reported to the extent possible:

1. Pre-impact observations, direction of trajectory, number of objects observed, time of impact, characteristics of impact area, and circumstances of recovery.
2. Description of any injury or damage caused by the object. Provide precise details to extent possible, but in making inquiries avoid stimulating claims, especially trivial or nuisance claims.

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3. Description of any identifying marks or letters.
4. Detailed description of the physical nature and condition of the object, including actual or estimated dimensions, weight, material, construction, etc.
5. If possible, photographs of the object (preferably in color) from various angles using a dimensional reference such as a ruler or pack of cigarettes.
6. Any other information which might be helpful in identifying the object or of interest to USG.

Based on the information provided by the post, the Department of State in conjunction with other interested agencies will determine subsequent action required.

The Outer Space Treaty obligates a party to return to the launching state space objects and their component parts which return to earth on its territory. The Return of Astronauts and Objects Agreement elaborates on this obligation, requiring that a party must notify a launching state and the UN Secretary General when it learns that a space object has landed on its territory. This treaty further provides that such an object must be returned if a request for return is made by the

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launching state. The launching state may be required to furnish identifying data prior to return of the object. The Outer Space Liability Convention elaborates rules and procedures concerning liability for damage caused by space objects and payment of compensation for such damage. Quotes of the relevant Articles of the Outer Space Treaty and the Astronauts and Objects Agreement are enclosed, as is the complete text of the Liability Convention.

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